

Sleeping With THE ENEMIES

The 15th General Elections, now underway, promise to breathe fresh meaning into that old saying about politics making strange bedfellows. And this is one of those elections where the one who gets to rule need not necessarily be the one that the people voted for. Sworn enemies will suddenly kiss to make up with ex-foes while the strength of numbers or the lack thereof may force long-term allies to snap links. When the results are out on May 16, a few things can be ruled out. Among them: Sonia Gandhi will not invite Lal Krishna Advani over to 10 Janpath nor will Prakash Karat entertain the BJP leader at Greater Kailash Part I. Mayawati will not offer to make a life-size statue of Mulayam Singh Yadav in return for his support nor will the Samajwadi Party seek similar help from the BSP supremo. Down south, the 25-year-old face-off between Karunanidhi and Jayalalithaa will carry on. Apart from these improbables, everything else is a possibility. Depending on who is with whom, this could be the best of times and the worst of times for both politicians and parties.

SCENARIO 1

IF

Congress gets around **160** seats
and its allies get **60** seats
They still need another **52** to cross the halfway mark.



$$160 + 60 + 52 = 272$$

Congress Allies Others

How will the shortfall be made up?

This is perhaps the first election in which there are three major contenders, all of whom think their chances of coming to power are as good as the others'. If the Congress manages to win **160** seats and along with its allies crosses the **220/230** mark, its managers will work the cellphone airwaves to rope in the bigger regional parties. If, for example, the AIADMK-led front in Tamil Nadu wins a majority of seats in the state, a desperate Congress could snap its links with the DMK and seek the AIADMK's help. It may also decide to snap its increasingly tenuous links with the RJD and woo the JD(U) whose seats would make up for the end of the five-year alliance.

SCENARIO 2

IF

Congress gets around **140** seats
and its allies get another **60** seats
They still need another **72** to cross the halfway mark.



$$140 + 60 + 72 = 272$$

Congress Allies Others

Where will this 72 come from?

The shortfall looks huge. Apart from wooing the AIADMK, JD(U) etc, the Congress will have to forge links with Deve Gowda and Chiranjeevi and hope the Left's instincts to keep the BJP out will force it to lend support to the UPA.

SCENARIO 3

IF

BJP gets around **160** seats
and its allies get around **60** seats
They still need another **52** to cross the halfway mark.



$$160 + 60 + 52 = 272$$

BJP Allies Others

Where can they hope to get 52 more?

With **220** MPs, the BJP-led NDA may well be within sniffing distance of power as erstwhile allies like Jayalalithaa, Mamata Banerjee, Naveen Patnaik and Chandrababu Naidu will begin the trek back even without a red carpet having to be rolled.

SCENARIO 4

IF

BJP gets **140** seats or under
and its allies win around **60** .
They still need another **72** to cross the halfway mark.



$$140 + 60 + 72 = 272$$

BJP Allies Others

A Bridge Too Far

These are the kind of numbers that could confirm the BJP's worst fears. Former allies will not glance back and present partners may begin to squirm in the BJP's company, forcing Advani to give up on his prime ministerial dreams completely.